

MASTER BUILDERS

Ottoman rulers commissioned many magnificent palaces and mosques as symbols of their great power, as well as to show their devotion to Islam. Ottoman architects were inspired by both Islamic and European art, and their buildings are a lively mix of both traditions.



SULTAN AHMED MOSQUE, ISTANBUL
Also known as the Blue Mosque, for the blue tiles that decorate its interior. It was built between 1609 and 1616.

The central dome is 23.5 m (77 ft) in diameter



DOLMABAHÇE PALACE
Home to six sultans until the deposition of the last sultan in 1922.



AHMET FOUNTAIN
Public drinking fountain built by Ahmed III in 1728. The water is supplied from a pool inside the kiosk.

ART AND DECORATION

As the Ottoman Empire grew richer and more powerful, artists and craftspeople were in great demand to produce art and objects for the sultan's palaces. The town of Iznik was particularly famous for beautiful ceramic tiles and pottery, which were decorated with flowers and intricate plant motifs and Arabic script, mainly in vivid shades of blue and green.



IZNIK PLATE



IZNIK CERAMIC TILES

Sheath is decorated with more than 50 diamonds

Enamel flower motif

WEAPONS AND ARMOUR

During the reign of Suleiman I, the Ottoman army was the largest and most successful in Europe. The sultan's troops were highly trained, well disciplined, and equipped with the latest weapons and armour.



HIDE AND COPPER CHICHAK (HELMET)



CUIRASS (BODY PROTECTOR)



STEEL HELMET



CHAIN-MAIL ARMOUR



MACE, DAGGER, AND SWORD



BREASTPLATE



CAVALRY BOOTS



KALKAN (SHIELD)

JEWELS AND FINERY

The Ottomans' taste was influenced by the variety of cultures across their vast empire. Jewellery was ornate and generally mixed different metals and gems in one piece. Emeralds and jade were popular because green was associated with the prophet Muhammad.



TOPKAPI DAGGER
Made as a gift from Sultan Mahmud I to the ruler of Persia, Nadir Shah, in 1747.

SPOONMAKER'S DIAMOND
86-carat, pear-shaped diamond in gold and 49-diamond setting.

NECKLACE
1875–1925

Hilt is decorated with three Colombian emeralds

Five pieces of different shapes are engraved with verses from the Qur'an